

Train to Edinburgh - Kids

UK Family Tour

Racing North on the Flying Scotsman's Line

You're riding one of the most famous railway lines in the world: the East Coast Main Line, from London King's Cross to Edinburgh — the route of the legendary Flying Scotsman. Trains have run this exact route since the 1850s, and in the old days, rival railway companies literally raced each other to Scotland, shaving minutes off, night after night, in what newspapers called the Races to the North. In 1934, the locomotive called Flying Scotsman became the first steam engine ever officially recorded at one hundred miles per hour. Four years later, on a stretch of this very line, a blue streamlined engine called Mallard hit one hundred twenty-six miles per hour — still the world speed record for steam, nearly ninety years later. Your train is faster and considerably less smoky. Things to watch for out the window: about halfway, look for Durham Cathedral and castle rising on a cliff above a river bend — one of the best views from any train in Britain, on the right side going north. Then comes the seaside: the line runs along the North Sea cliffs, and if you watch carefully near Alnmouth and Berwick you might spot castles on the coast. Keep a tally: sheep, castles, and the sea. First one to a hundred sheep wins.

The Bullet Train and a Queen Under the Floor

Right now you're sitting on one of the fastest trains in Britain, and here's a secret about it. This train was probably built here in the North of England, in a factory in County Durham that you'll roll right past later today. The design came from Japan, and the name of the fastest of these trains is Azuma, which is a Japanese word that means "east," because you're riding the East Coast line. So you're on a Japanese-named, English-built machine that can cruise at around one hundred twenty-five miles an hour, almost as fast as that record-breaking steam engine from ninety years ago, except yours is smooth and quiet and doesn't need a single lump of coal.

Think back to the platform you left from. King's Cross station has a very famous secret wall, halfway between platforms nine and ten, where a luggage trolley sticks out of the bricks and a sign reads Platform Nine and Three-Quarters. That's the magic platform from Harry Potter, where the train to Hogwarts leaves. Loads of people line up to have their photo taken pretending to push the trolley through the wall. Your train left from a perfectly normal platform nearby, no wizards required.

Now here's the wow for this chapter. A while into the journey you pass the city of Peterborough and its enormous cathedral. Under the stone floor of that cathedral lies a real queen of England, Catherine of Aragon, the first wife of King Henry the Eighth, the king with six wives. And for a few years, another queen was buried there too, Mary Queen of Scots, before her son the king had her moved to London. So without even slowing down, your speeding train just zoomed past the grave of a queen.

One more thing to watch for early in the trip. Soon after King's Cross, the train dived into a dark tunnel, then popped back out into the daylight. If you were watching the left side, you might have spotted a huge palace on a hilltop with a giant glass front. That's Alexandra Palace, nicknamed Ally Pally, where the very first proper television pictures in the world were beamed out, back in 1936. Imagine that, the first ever telly show in history, sent out from a palace on a hill.

Here's a number to chew on while the fields whizz past. Your train is covering more than fifty meters every single second, about half the length of a football pitch. Blink, and a whole field has vanished behind you. Keep your eyes on the window. The best sights are still coming.

The Duck That Broke the World Record

Let's talk about that record-breaking engine again, because the story gets better. The fastest steam locomotive in the history of the world was named after a duck. It's true. The engine was called Mallard, which is a kind of wild duck, the one with the shiny green head that you see on ponds. And Mallard wasn't the only bird in the family. The engineer who built these engines, Sir Nigel Gresley, gave a whole flock of them bird names. There was Bittern, and Kingfisher, and Wild Swan, and Seagull, and Golden Plover. A whole stable full of birds, all built for speed.

Why a duck for the fastest one? Because these engines were shaped to slip through the air like a bird in flight. Most steam engines back then were big and boxy and flat at the front, which is terrible for going fast, because the air pushes straight back against a flat wall. But Gresley shaped the front of Mallard into a smooth, rounded, sloping nose, like the front of a modern bullet train, so the air slid up and over it instead of shoving against it. They even tested the shape by blowing wind at little models, the way you'd test a paper airplane. And they painted Mallard a beautiful deep blue, so it looked as fast as it truly was.

On the third of July, in 1938, on a long gentle downhill slope not far south of where you started today, Mallard went thundering down the hill and hit one hundred twenty-six miles per hour. That beat the old record, which had belonged to a German engine, by about a mile and a half an hour. Here's the amazing part. That was almost ninety years ago, and no steam engine anywhere on Earth has ever gone faster since. Not one. The record has stood longer than your grandparents have been alive.

Think about how fast that really is. Going down the hill, Mallard's tall wheels were spinning round about five hundred times every minute, the fire was roaring, and the whole heavy iron machine was shaking and screaming. The men on board could actually smell hot metal, because a part deep inside the engine was beginning to melt from the sheer effort. They had pushed it right to the very edge, snatched the record, and eased off just in time before anything broke.

Mallard is still around today. It doesn't run anymore, but it sits, polished and blue and beautiful, in the National Railway Museum in the city of York, which your train passes through. If you ever go inside, you can stand right next to the actual duck that beat the whole world. Give a little quack as you pass York. Mallard has earned it.

The Bridges of the Tyne and the Giant Angel

Coming up is one of the best window moments of the whole trip, so get ready. When your train reaches the city of Newcastle, it crosses a wide river called the Tyne, high up on a bridge, and for about ten seconds you get a view of a whole family of bridges all crowded together over the water, one after another after another. See how many you can count.

There's a fat green one shaped like a giant arch, called the Tyne Bridge. There's a clever one that actually tilts and lifts up to let boats through, and when it opens it looks exactly like a giant winking eye, which is why everyone calls it the Blinking Eye. And there's an old double-decker bridge with trains running on the top and cars driving underneath, built more than a hundred and seventy years ago by the son of the man they call the father of the railways. All of them, packed into one short stretch of river. It's like the bridges are showing off.

Then, a few minutes later, look to the side for something even bigger, standing up on a hill. A giant. It's a statue called the Angel of the North, and it is enormous. It stands as tall as five double-decker buses

stacked on top of each other, and its two outstretched wings are as wide as the wings of a passenger jet, tip to tip. It's made of rust-colored steel, the same tough steel they use to build ships, and it was made rusty on purpose, so it turns a lovely warm orange-brown and never needs painting. It has stood on that hill since 1998, welcoming everyone who travels north, with its wings held out just a little bit forward, almost as if it's about to give the whole of Northern England a hug.

More than thirty million people see the Angel every year, most of them from cars and trains just like yours. Here's a fact to boast about later: the whole thing weighs about two hundred tonnes, heavier than a hundred cars put together, and it was built strong enough to stand up in winds fierce enough to knock you flat on your back. Now you're one of them. Wave hello. And keep counting those sheep and castles, because you're getting close to Scotland now, and the seaside part of the ride, with the real castles by the water, is about to begin.

Crossing into Scotland

Just after the town of Berwick-upon-Tweed, your train rumbles over the Royal Border Bridge — twenty-eight huge stone arches, forty meters above the River Tweed, opened by Queen Victoria in 1850. A few minutes later, you cross an invisible line: the border between England and Scotland. No fence, no passport check — but you're now in a different country within the United Kingdom, and you'll notice it fast. Scotland has its own flag, the white X on blue, called the Saltire. Its own banknotes — Scottish pounds, which are real money but look completely different. Its own national animal, which is, genuinely, the unicorn. And its own accent, which you'll be happily confused by within the hour. Poor Berwick, the town you just passed, changed hands between England and Scotland more than a dozen times over the centuries as the two countries fought over it — it's England's most bitten-over town, and its football team, funnily enough, plays in the Scottish leagues to this day. As you get close to Edinburgh, watch the right side for the sea and the left for hills. When you step out at Waverley station, look up: you'll be in a valley with a castle on a cliff right above you. That's tomorrow's adventure staring down at you.

Holy Island and the Vikings

As your train runs along the seaside in the far north of England, watch the window for the North Sea, and keep an eye out for a low island just off the coast with a little castle on it. That's Holy Island, also called Lindisfarne, and it has one of the strangest features of any place in Britain. Twice a day, it isn't an island at all.

Here's how it works. A narrow road runs across the sand from the mainland out to the island. But when the tide comes in, the sea rises and floods right over that road, and the whole thing vanishes under the water. For hours, nobody can drive on or off. Then the tide goes out again, the road reappears dripping with seaweed, and the island joins back onto the land. People who forget to check the tide times sometimes have to scramble up onto a little wooden rescue tower and wait there, with their car sitting underwater below them, feeling very silly indeed.

More than a thousand years ago, this tiny island was one of the most important and most peaceful places in the whole country. Monks lived there in a monastery, quietly making the most beautiful books you have ever seen, hand-painted with gold and swirling patterns and tiny creatures hidden inside the letters, one page at a time. One of those books, called the Lindisfarne Gospels, has actually survived to this day, more than thirteen hundred years old, and it is now so precious that it lives inside a special case in a great library down in London. And then, in the year 793, something terrifying happened. Longships appeared on the water, filled with warriors from across the sea. The Vikings had arrived. They stormed the island, smashed the church, stole the treasure and the golden books, and sailed away. People all across the country were horrified. Nobody had ever dared attack a holy place like that before. Many historians say that awful day was the true beginning of the age of the Vikings in Britain.

So as you glide past Holy Island in your warm, comfy train, picture those longships out on the cold grey water, and the frightened monks, and be very glad you're arriving in a rather friendlier century than they did.

Castles by the Sea

This stretch of coast, in a part of England called Northumberland, has more castles than almost anywhere else in the whole country, and from the train you have a real chance of spotting them. So this chapter is a challenge. Become a castle-hunter.

The biggest one to watch for sits on a giant rock right above the beach, above a huge stretch of pale golden sand. It's called Bamburgh Castle, and it is exactly what a castle is supposed to look like, long walls and tall towers standing guard over the sea. Real kings ruled the whole north of England from that rock more than a thousand years ago. Waves crash on the shore below it, and on a windy day the sea spray flies right up the cliff. And just out to sea from here, on a wild stormy night long ago, a brave young woman named Grace Darling rowed a tiny rowing boat out through the crashing waves to rescue drowning sailors from a wrecked ship. She became the most famous girl in the whole country, and people still tell her story nearly two hundred years later.

A little further along, tucked inland, is another famous one you might not see from the train but really should know about. Alnwick Castle. If it looks familiar in photos, that's because it played the part of Hogwarts School in the very first Harry Potter films. The young wizards learned to fly their broomsticks in its courtyard. And here's the best bit. Real children can take actual broomstick-flying lessons there today, which sounds like the greatest school trip ever invented.

And there's a spooky one too, called Dunstanburgh, except this one is a ruin. Just jagged, broken towers standing all alone on an empty headland, with no road to reach them. You have to walk a long way across the fields to get there, past the sheep, and when you finally see it looming up, grey and crumbling against the sky, it looks like exactly the sort of place where a dragon might live.

So here's your mission for the next half hour. Press your nose to the glass and look for anything with stone walls and towers, up on the hills or down by the shore. Every castle counts. Shout it out the moment you spot one. Whoever has counted the most castles by the time you cross the border into Scotland is the official Castle Champion of the entire family. Ready? Eyes on the window. Go.

A Volcano and a Station in a Vanished Lake

The last part of your journey is the prettiest of all. After you cross into Scotland, the train hugs the coast again and runs past a little seaside town called Dunbar. Here's a story an American should love. A boy was born in that town, long ago, named John Muir. He grew up climbing the cliffs and poking about in the rock-pools right there. Then he sailed away to America, fell head over heels in love with its wild mountains, and spent the rest of his life persuading people to protect them. Because of John Muir, from tiny Dunbar, America created some of its greatest national parks, including Yosemite, with its towering cliffs and thundering waterfalls. A Scottish boy helped save the wild places of America.

Now watch ahead, because Edinburgh is about to appear, and it appears in the most dramatic way possible. Rising up out of the city is a great green hill with a rocky top. That hill is called Arthur's Seat, and it is an extinct volcano. Don't worry, it hasn't erupted in more than three hundred million years, so you're perfectly safe, but the whole city was built around the bones of an ancient volcano. And on another great chunk of old volcanic rock, a steep black cliff, stands Edinburgh Castle, keeping watch over everything. See if you can spot it up there. You'll get to climb right up to it tomorrow. And here's a lovely bit of Edinburgh weirdness to listen out for: nearly every day, at exactly one o'clock, the castle fires a real cannon, with a great booming bang that rolls out across the whole city, so that everybody can check their watches by it.

Then your train slides into the station, which is called Waverley, and here comes the last surprise. The station sits down in a deep valley in the very middle of the city. But hundreds of years ago, that valley wasn't a valley at all, it was a lake. A smelly, mucky, murky lake called the Nor Loch. The townspeople drained all the water away, and where the lake used to be, they built the railway station and some gardens. So when you step off the train, remember this. You're standing at the bottom of a lake that isn't there anymore, underneath a castle that sits on a volcano. Welcome to Edinburgh. It's going to be brilliant.